

Foods to Avoid With Arthritis: A Complete UK Guide

Discover which foods trigger inflammation and joint pain — and what to eat instead.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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If you live with arthritis in the UK, you already know that pain and stiffness can fluctuate from one day to the next. While there is no single diet that cures arthritis, mounting research confirms that certain foods consistently worsen inflammation — the very process driving joint damage and pain. Understanding which foods to avoid with arthritis is one of the most practical, cost-free steps you can take alongside your prescribed treatment.



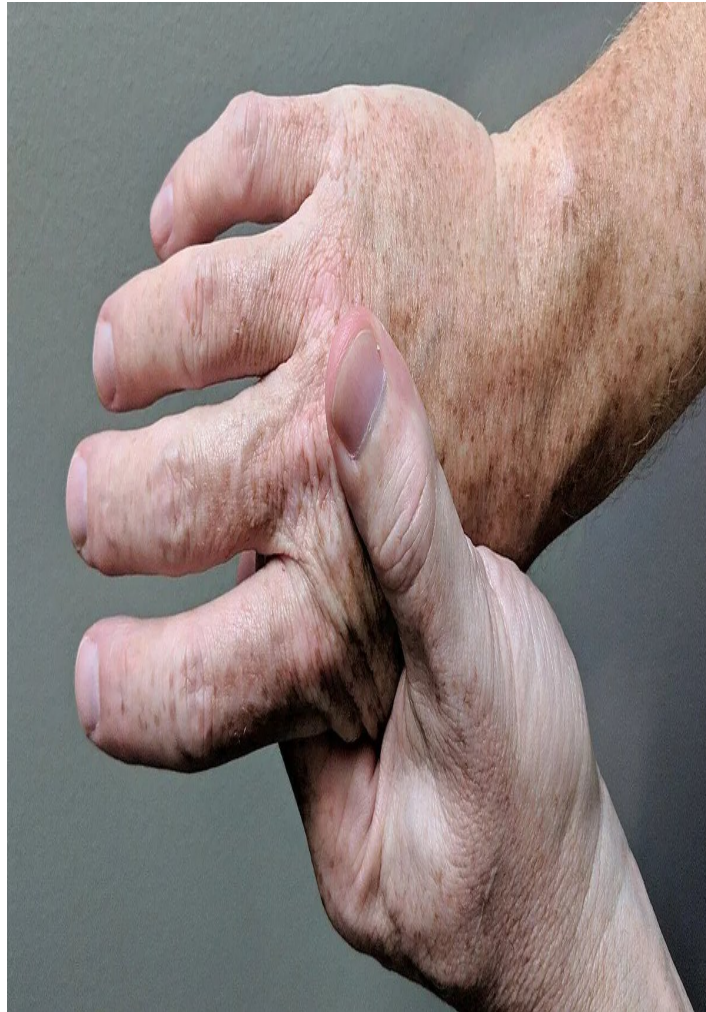
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This guide covers the key dietary culprits identified in clinical research, explains why they affect your joints, and offers simple swaps you can make today. Whether you have osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis, psoriatic arthritis, or gout, the principles largely overlap.

Why Does Diet Affect Arthritis?

Arthritis is broadly an inflammatory condition. Rheumatoid arthritis (RA) involves an overactive immune system attacking joint tissue; osteoarthritis (OA) involves cartilage breakdown accompanied by low-grade inflammation. Either way, what you eat directly influences your body's inflammatory pathways.

Certain foods raise levels of pro-inflammatory cytokines such as IL-6, TNF-alpha, and CRP — markers commonly measured in blood tests for arthritis. Others flood the bloodstream with advanced glycation end-products (AGEs) that stiffen joint tissue. A 2023 review published in **Nutrients** found that patients who reduced processed food consumption reported a statistically significant reduction in pain scores within 12 weeks.



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1. Ultra-Processed Foods and Fast Food

Ultra-processed foods (UPFs) — including ready meals, crisps, packaged biscuits, processed meats such as sausages and deli slices, and fast-food items — are the biggest dietary threat for people with arthritis. They are dense in trans fats, refined carbohydrates, artificial additives, and preservatives, all of which promote systemic inflammation.

A UK Biobank study found that higher UPF consumption was independently associated with increased odds of developing inflammatory arthritis. If a food has more than five ingredients on the label and many of them are unrecognisable chemical names, it almost certainly qualifies as ultra-processed.

****Quick swaps**** - Replace crisps with a small handful of unsalted walnuts or pumpkin seeds. - Swap processed sausages for grilled chicken thighs or oily fish. - Choose homemade soups

over tinned varieties loaded with sodium and additives.



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2. Sugar and High-Fructose Foods

Sugar is a powerful inflammation trigger. Excess sugar in the diet raises blood glucose, which in turn stimulates the release of inflammatory cytokines. It also encourages weight gain — and every extra kilogram places roughly four kilograms of additional stress on each knee joint.

High-fructose corn syrup, commonly found in fizzy drinks, energy drinks, flavoured yogurts, and many breakfast cereals, is particularly harmful. Fructose is metabolised by the liver and, in excess, converts to uric acid — a direct cause of gout flares. People with gout should be especially vigilant about fruit juices, which can deliver a large fructose hit without the fibre buffer of whole fruit.

3. Refined Carbohydrates

White bread, white rice, pasta made from refined flour, pastries, and most commercially produced cakes and muffins spike blood sugar rapidly, triggering an inflammatory cascade. They lack the fibre and nutrients of their wholegrain equivalents and offer little benefit to joint health.

The glycaemic index (GI) is a useful tool: foods with a GI above 70 — such as white baguette, cornflakes, or instant mashed potato — cause the fastest blood sugar spikes. Swapping these for low-GI alternatives (oats, wholegrain rye bread, sweet potato, brown basmati rice) is one of the most evidence-based dietary changes for reducing arthritis-related inflammation.

4. Omega-6 Fatty Acids and Vegetable Oils

Not all fats are equal. The typical British diet contains far too many omega-6 fatty acids relative to anti-inflammatory omega-3s. Omega-6 fats, found abundantly in sunflower oil, corn oil, and soya oil — oils used heavily in restaurant cooking and packaged snacks — are precursors to pro-inflammatory eicosanoids.

Ideally the omega-6 to omega-3 ratio in the diet should be 4:1 or lower. Many people in the UK currently consume a ratio closer to 15:1 or even 20:1. Reducing fried foods, limiting vegetable oil use at home, and increasing oily fish intake (salmon, mackerel, sardines, herring) is the most practical way to rebalance this ratio.

5. Alcohol

Alcohol interacts with arthritis in multiple ways. It is directly pro-inflammatory, interfering with the gut microbiome and increasing intestinal permeability — sometimes called 'leaky gut' — which allows bacterial toxins to enter the bloodstream and stimulate immune activation.

Beer is particularly problematic for people with gout because it contains both alcohol and purines (compounds that metabolise to uric acid). Even moderate beer consumption can double the risk of a gout attack. Spirits and wine are somewhat lower in purines but still increase uric acid production. If you have gout, the safest approach is to significantly limit or eliminate alcohol, especially beer and stout.

6. Dairy Products (For Some People)

The evidence on dairy is more nuanced. Full-fat dairy — butter, cream, full-fat cheese, and whole milk — contains saturated fats that can promote inflammation in some individuals, particularly those with RA. However, low-fat dairy such as skimmed milk and low-fat yogurt may actually be protective against gout due to a mechanism that promotes uric acid excretion.

If you notice that dairy products worsen your symptoms, consider an elimination trial under the guidance of a registered dietitian. Some people find that switching to plant-based alternatives reduces flare frequency, though evidence for this remains anecdotal for most arthritis types.

7. Salt and High-Sodium Foods

Excess sodium intake drives fluid retention and can worsen joint swelling. It also appears to activate Th17 immune cells — the same cells implicated in autoimmune forms of arthritis like RA and psoriatic arthritis. Research from Yale University demonstrated that a high-salt diet significantly worsened autoimmune disease in animal models.

Processed and takeaway foods are the biggest sources of hidden sodium in the UK diet. UK guidelines recommend no more than 6g of salt per day for adults; many takeaway meals contain this in a single serving. Reading food labels and cooking from scratch are the most effective strategies.

Quick Answer

People with arthritis should avoid ultra-processed foods, sugary drinks, refined carbohydrates, foods high in omega-6 fats (like sunflower-oil-fried foods), alcohol (especially beer if you have gout), and high-sodium processed foods. These foods increase inflammation, raise uric acid levels, and worsen joint pain.

What Should You Eat Instead?

An anti-inflammatory diet rich in oily fish, colourful vegetables, legumes, wholegrains, olive oil, nuts, and seeds is strongly associated with reduced arthritis symptoms. The Mediterranean diet, in particular, has robust clinical evidence behind it for RA and OA. Aim to fill half your plate with vegetables at every meal, choose oily fish at least twice a week, and use extra-virgin olive oil as your primary cooking fat.

Practical Steps Starting Today

You do not need to overhaul your entire diet at once. Start with these three changes:

1. Cut out fizzy drinks and fruit juice — replace with water, herbal teas, or green tea. 2. Switch to wholegrain bread and pasta instead of white versions. 3. Add one portion of oily fish per week if you do not already eat it.

Track your symptoms in a food and pain diary over four to six weeks. Many people with arthritis notice a meaningful difference within this timeframe when they reduce the foods listed in this article.

Conclusion

Managing arthritis is a lifelong journey, and diet is one of the few areas where you have real, daily control. While no food change replaces your prescribed medication or physiotherapy, reducing your intake of ultra-processed foods, sugar, refined carbs, excess omega-6 fats, alcohol, and salt can meaningfully reduce inflammation and improve your quality of life. For personalised advice, ask your GP for a referral to a registered dietitian who specialises in musculoskeletal conditions.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about foods to avoid with arthritis: a complete uk guide?

Short answer: For arthritis, the guide advises limiting ultra-processed foods, sugary drinks, refined carbohydrates, omega-6-rich vegetable oils and fried foods, alcohol, especially beer for gout, high-salt processed foods and sometimes full-fat dairy. It says these can worsen inflammation, uric acid, swelling and joint pain, while wholegrains, oily fish, vegetables, olive oil, nuts and seeds are suggested swaps.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk